THE GENDER DIVIDE IN GOING TO WORK

The National Household Travel Survey 2025-26 shows that women often walk or take the bus to their workplace, while men prefer two-wheelers. That limits their life-chances

BUS

All-India	Urban	Rural
14	21.7	9.9
5.3	6.9	4.4
6.7	9.2	5.3



If reliable and safe networks with last-mile connectivity are not available to women, they don't travel. Concessional travel, not the free ticket, has proven more popular among women

TWO-WHEELER

All-India	Urban	Rural
18.4	25.8	14.5
47.1	57	41.5
42.6	52.3	37.1



With bikes and scooters, men make up for lack of affordable public transport in cities, leaving women without a solution to avail faraway work opportunities

WALKING

All-India	Urban	Rural
50.6	24	64.8
24.1	11.6	31.2
28.3	13.5	36.6



People walking at least a kilometre to work do it to save money. A domestic worker may skip work at a better-paying factory because it's far away. Policy has neglected wide footpaths and favoured the needs of motorists and metro-riders

Women | Men | All; figures in %

WOMEN STILL FEEL TRAVEL IS NOT SAFE

Poor infrastructure for walkers and cyclists hampers the commute of India's most vulnerable: women, the elderly and children. Roads and bus networks need to be made safe and accessible at all times of day

The big numbers would make a man say women have it better. Nationally, those who travel to work for a kilometre or more pay less than men to get there—Rs 533 every month, or some 37 per cent less. But ask Karthick M.P., vice-president for programmes and research at the Udaiti Foundation, and you will be told this figure isn't a sign of a robust transportation network that prioritises women's safety. "It's just a sign that they travel less," he says. That's not out of choice.

The National Household Travel Survey finds that 61.9 per cent of male workers make such a trip every day, compared to only 41.9 per cent women. While the gap is less in cities—nearly 14 percentage points—it rises above the national average to 22 percentage points in villages.

41.9
PER CENT
of female workers undertake daily work journeys of one kilometre or more, compared with 61.9 per cent of male workers

Karthick says these numbers hide more than they show. If women feel unsafe, he says, they pay for a cab instead of taking the metro, and the survey will not notice as it records distance travelled. Jagan Shah, a senior expert in urban development policy and practice, adds that excluding trips under a kilometre are a glaring omission in the survey as hyperlocal trips and pedestrian space are not in its purview.

"Women rely on walking and public buses much more," says Rutul Joshi, a